# WRITING JOURNAL 1

**Journal Entry 1**

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Prompt: After this class, write an entry about your own personal experience of #interpretivelens. Explain how you became aware of your own #interpretivelens in interpreting a communicative text (defined loosely here - can be a literary, journalistic, visual, aural, or multimedia text).

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*Date: Wednesday, September 11 | Time Intended: 1 hour | Time Spent: 1 hour | HC: #interpretivelens*

*Purpose for Writing:*

I want to use this opportunity not just to complete an assignment but to reflect deeply on the texts I've read over the past few years. While I frequently discuss how a handful of books have influenced my perspectives, I haven't had the chance to truly analyze how and why these changes occurred. Additionally, I see this as a chance to hone in my narrative writing skills. Although I've written many articles, newsletters, and analytical essays in school, I haven't had much practice with creative or narrative writing where I can express my emotions and thoughts more freely. As I began working on personal statements and essays for college applications, I realized how out of practice I am in this area.

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"Our first book on the reading list is *The Book of Trespas* by Nick Hayes," my economics teacher declared with a dramatic flourish, holding up the book for everyone to see. The cover was a vivid splash of bold red lines: a deer standing apprehensively against a backdrop of tangled

barbed wire. The image was jarring, a far cry from the mundane school textbooks I was used to. I couldn't help but think, "This is stupid." The book seemed like a bizarre choice, completely out of sync with the rigid, numbers-driven world of economics I was expecting.

When Arvin (not Mr. Dang or Professor Dang) handed me *The Book of Trespass*, I rolled my eyes. I had always seen him as an oddity—a former Wall Street economist turned Sherpa turned teacher. Growing up in a conservative, predominantly white town before moving to a liberal international boarding school, I was accustomed to a specific view of what education should be. To me, my teacher's suggestion felt like a misguided detour from the conventional, grades-focused education I was used to. I thought of him as a "hippie" with questionable ideas and had little interest in what seemed like an irrelevant book.

With a sense of obligation rather than curiosity, I started reading *The Book of Trespass*. My initial approach was dismissive; I skimmed through the pages, eager to find evidence that it was a waste of time. My focus was on finishing the book quickly so I could return to my "real" studies. But as I continued reading, something unexpected happened. Hayes' storytelling surrounding the dynamics of ownership and access began to catch my interest. His examination of how property and space are tied to social inequality and historical injustices opened my eyes in ways I hadn't anticipated.

The deeper I got into the book, especially the chapter on women's rights and historical power dynamics (Spider), I realized how much my initial judgment was clouded by bias. Hayes wasn't just discussing land laws; he was unravelling a complex history of exclusion and control

that resonated far beyond economics. For example, in "Spider," Hayes explores how women were systematically marginalized, from witch hunts to their exclusion based on the power they wielded through gossip at the commons. Chapters like this led me to view the text through a new lens, prompting me to question my own assumptions about education and learning. The book was forcing me to confront my own narrow view of what was valuable in an academic context.

This revelation was a turning point for me. I understood that my initial resistance was a result of my own limited perspective. I had judged my teacher and his recommendations based on my own preconceived notions, rather than engaging with the material openly. *The Book of Trespass* wasn't a detour from my academic goals; it was a profound lesson in how important it is to be open to new ideas and perspectives. By the time I finished the book, my view of learning had shifted dramatically. I realized that education isn't just about following a prescribed path to achieve good grades. It's about exploring diverse viewpoints, challenging my own assumptions, and embracing ideas that initially seem foreign or irrelevant. This experience taught me that sometimes the most valuable lessons come from unexpected places and that being willing to question and expand my interpretive lens can lead to profound personal growth.[1]

[1] In applying #responsibility, I dedicated time to this entry and faced the challenge of writing narratively (the style I chose to practice). By revising my work and analyzing the narrative style of the text, I immersed myself in the moment my narrative is based on while reflecting on it in hindsight. This approach helped me overcome the obstacles and produce a thoughtful entry.

**Journal Entry 2**

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Prompt: Write in your journal something from the Chiang short story you noticed through close reading (not discussed in class) and write up a short #critique.

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*Date: Wednesday, September 18 | Time Intended: 1 hour | Time Spent: 1 hour 45 minutes | HC: #critique*

*Purpose for Writing:*

Several points of investigation intrigued me. For instance, I was fascinated by how the story begins and ends with the same statement (similar to a book I enjoy, *The Outsiders*), which highlighted Louise's experience of living through all time—past, present, and future—simultaneously. This led me to further develop the themes of free will vs determinism. Since we didn't have the opportunity to explore these topics extensively in class, I used this space to discuss their connections and investigate how they add significant depth to the narrative.

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Ted Chiang's short story Story of Your Life talks about complex themes of time, language, free will, and determinism, inviting readers into a narrative that reflects both philosophical and linguistic inquiries. Through a close reading, I observed how Chiang uses narrative structure, tense manipulation, and recurring motifs to deepen the readers' understanding of these themes—particularly in ways that weren't discussed in class. One aspect that stands out through a more focused analysis is how Chiang frames the narrative with a recurring proposition and how he uses the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis as a lens to explore the human experience of time.

Together, these elements provide a nuanced exploration of the tension between free will and determinism, ultimately suggesting that our lives, despite being constrained by certain inevitabilities, are imbued with meaning through the choices we make.

As we touched on in class, Chiang draws heavily on the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, which suggests that language shapes thought and influences how individuals perceive reality. Chiang uses this concept to explore the way Louise Banks' mastery of Heptapod B transforms her perception of time. What stands out here is that Chiang doesn't treat this idea as purely theoretical; instead, he immerses readers in Louise's evolving comprehension of time through his manipulation of tenses and narrative structure. What we didn't fully explore in class is how Chiang extends this idea beyond language itself by framing the entire story in a way that echoes this lack of linearity (specifically with its opening and closing statements).

The story's structural framing—marked by the recurring question, "Do you want to make a baby?"—provides another layer of meaning related to time, choice, and acceptance. At first, the question seems to reflect a personal decision between Louise and her partner, but as her understanding of time expands, it takes on a broader existential significance. The repetition of this proposition at both the beginning and the end of the narrative emphasizes the simultaneous yet cyclical nature of time, mirroring the Heptapods' non-linear worldview. Just as their language allows them to perceive all events simultaneously rather than sequentially, the circular structure of the story reflects this specific perception of reality. At the beginning of the story, the framing device may seem confusing and irrelevant, but by the time you finish and connect the narrative's dots, it takes on much deeper significance. By the end of the story, it's clear that the

question, “Do you want to make a baby?” is more than a query about parenthood—it is a meditation on fate, choice, and the acceptance of life’s inevitable pain and joy.[2]

Louise’s foreknowledge of her daughter’s short life could be seen as an argument for determinism—her future is already set, and there’s nothing she can do to change it. But what’s striking about the story is that Louise’s foreknowledge does not lead her to resist her fate or attempt to change the outcome. Instead, she embraces it fully, choosing to live within the moments of joy and sorrow as they unfold. This is where Chiang’s portrayal of free will diverges from a traditional understanding. Rather than seeing foreknowledge as a form of entrapment, Louise’s acceptance of her future represents an active, intentional engagement with her life. Knowing what’s to come doesn’t diminish the value of her experiences; if anything, it enhances them by giving her the opportunity to appreciate each moment more deeply. In this sense, Chiang’s story offers a rethinking of what it means to exercise free will. Rather than focusing on the ability to change the future, the story suggests that true agency lies in how we choose to engage with the inevitabilities of life.

In the end, Chiang’s story is not just about language, time, or determinism—it is a meditation on the nature of human existence. The Sapir-Whorf hypothesis, the cyclical narrative structure, and the tension between free will and determinism all converge to explore what it means to live fully in the face of inevitable loss. As my time at UWC, the high school that held some of the best years of my life, drew to a close, I felt the inevitable sadness of leaving behind a

[2] Here, the #interpretivelens is used to analyze how the cyclical nature of the story alters the reader's interpretation. By framing the narrative this way, the author demonstrates how language shapes perception, both through Louise’s experiences and in a meta sense by influencing the reader's understanding of the story's format.

place filled with so many memories. But something my English teacher often reminded us of was the ephemerality of these experiences—that their fleeting nature is precisely what makes them so special. Just as Louise's journey raises the profound question: if we knew the future, would we live our lives any differently? Her answer is no—her knowledge of what's to come doesn't lessen the value of her experiences; it deepens her appreciation for life's fleeting moments. Similarly, knowing my time at UWC was temporary didn't make it any less meaningful. In fact, it heightened my sense of gratitude for every moment I spent there.[3]

Knowing that something will end doesn't take away its significance; it makes it all the more precious. Both in Chiang's story and in my own life, the fleeting nature of time is what drives us to cherish the present and live fully, even in the face of inevitable goodbyes.[4]

[3] I use my #context as a UWC student to shape my #interpretivelens when reading the book. My experiences at UWC, allow me to connect deeply with Louise's journey. This personal context enriches my interpretation, highlighting how awareness of ephemerality fosters appreciation for the present.

[4] In applying #responsibility, I used my annotations to identify intriguing points for investigation that weren't discussed in class. An obstacle I faced was exploring not just the "what" of the narrative but also the "how" Chiang used textual features to examine determinism and its significance. I overcame this by connecting my writing to my own #interpretivelens, analyzing my perspective alongside those of Louise and Chiang.

**Journal Entry 3**

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Prompt: Write an HC footnote justification for #critique for your journal entry 2.

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*Date: Thursday, September 26 | Time Intended: 20 minutes | Time Spent: 15 minutes | HC: #critique*

*Purpose for Writing:*

Practicing how to write HC footnote justifications, is a useful skill that will be used in many or all of our assignments to effectively signpost our intentions in writing and demonstrate fulfillment of the HC rubric. Through this, I aim to develop clarity in articulating how my analysis and interpretive choices align with the criteria and purpose of higher-level critique.

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In applying #critique, I examined how Chiang's narrative structure and the Sapir-Whorf hypothesis deepen the thematic exploration of determinism and free will in Story of Your Life. A challenge I encountered was moving beyond the discussion of these ideas in class to analyze how Chiang's manipulation of time and language specifically contributes to the reader's understanding of these themes. I addressed this by engaging with the text through a more focused #interpretivelens, exploring how the cyclical structure and recurring motifs reinforce the non-linear perception of time, offering a more nuanced critique of fate and human agency.

**Journal Entry 4**

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Prompt: Describe an issue you care about that you think is worthy of a strong and clear #thesis to convince others on this issue.

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*Date: Thursday, October 3 | Time Intended: 20 minutes | Time Spent: 15 minutes | HC: #thesis*

*Purpose for Writing:*

The purpose of this writing is to connect my passion for addressing the harmful effects of fast fashion with a strong argumentative thesis. By examining the environmental damage and worker exploitation linked to fast fashion, I aim to develop a compelling thesis that highlights the urgency of this issue. Using examples like Shein, I want to inspire readers to support eco-friendly brands and sustainable practices while refining my skills in crafting persuasive arguments on topics I care about.

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An issue I care about is the harmful impact of fast fashion on both the environment and workers in developing countries. The fast fashion industry generates millions of tons of textile waste each year, contributes to 20% of global wastewater, and is responsible for 10% of worldwide carbon emissions. Moreover, it often relies on low-wage labour, exploiting workers under poor conditions. Brands like Shein epitomize this problem, prioritizing quantity over quality, fueling a culture of micro-trends, wasting vast amounts of fabric, and being notorious for child labour and sweatshops with shockingly low wages. A compelling argument could highlight how fast fashion's unsustainable practices not only damage the planet but also violate human

rights. It would encourage consumers to support ethical alternatives by choosing eco-friendly brands, buying secondhand, and reducing overconsumption. It is essential to educate oneself on how micro-trends fuel the fast fashion industry and to actively avoid brands that engage in exploitative labour practices. Additionally, promoting upcycling, learning to mend, and repairing clothes—such as fixing small holes or missing buttons—can prevent perfectly wearable items from being discarded. Convincing people to move away from fast fashion is vital for fostering environmental sustainability and ensuring fair labour practices.

**Journal Entry 5**

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Prompt: Write in your journal what you thought was the most compelling piece of evidence on identity in this unit so far (From one of these authors: Love, Pavia, Galston, The New York Times video, or Appiah). Write an HC footnote for #evidencebased as though you used this evidence and this was your essay for which you will receive HC scores.

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*Date: Thursday, October 14th | Time Intended: 30 minutes | Time Spent: 1 hour| HC: #evidencebased*

*Purpose for Writing:*

In this journal entry, I used the opportunity to further dissect Appiah's writing and explore how he makes his work compelling by diversifying the types of evidence he employs to support his arguments. I look at the impacts of each type of evidence he uses - such as the appeal to pathos in personal anecdotes - and the appeal to logos/ethos in intellectual history and case studies. I also use this entry to practice using evidence in essay writing through the HC footnote.

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In my reflection on the unit, I found Kwame Anthony Appiah's discussion on identity in The Lies That Bind the most compelling, especially the persuasive rhetoric around how identities are formed and contested. One point that stood out was his argument that we often mistakenly assume there is some deep essence at the core of identities that unites individuals (Appiah, 2018). This notion reflects essentialism, where we believe a hidden, unobservable trait defines a group. He effectively deconstructs various concepts of identity by utilizing a diverse range of

evidence—such as personal anecdotes, intellectual history, and case studies—crafting a comprehensive narrative that makes his work the most compelling piece of literature we've studied in this class.

Through personal anecdotes, Appiah recounts his own experience of being mistaken for different ethnicities in various countries. In one instance, a London taxi driver refused to believe that Appiah didn't speak Hindi, illustrating how identity is often judged based on external appearances and cultural assumptions rather than any inherent, deep-rooted essence. In exploring intellectual history, Appiah investigates how modern conceptions of identity, particularly racial categories, were shaped during the 19th century. He critiques early scientific theories that sought to classify people based on superficial traits like skin colour, highlighting how these outdated ideas continue to influence contemporary understandings of identity. Lastly, Appiah draws on case studies, such as the Robbers Cave experiment, where boys quickly formed group identities based on arbitrary divisions. This study demonstrates how identities can be socially constructed and manipulated, reinforcing Appiah's argument that identity is fluid rather than fixed.

These different types of evidence not only build a more comprehensive and concrete argument but also enhance the variety of persuasive techniques he uses. Through personal anecdotes, Appiah appeals to pathos, drawing readers into a more emotional and immersive connection with the text. Meanwhile, his use of intellectual history and case studies appeals to both logos and ethos, providing logical reasoning and credible research to support his claims. Overall, the diverse range of evidence and persuasive strategies Appiah employs makes his text

the most compelling in its ability to challenge essentialist views on identity while engaging readers on both emotional and intellectual levels.

HC Footnote:

This essay demonstrates a strong application of #evidencebased by highlighting key evidence, such as Appiah's personal anecdotes and critiques of intellectual history to reinforce the thesis that his diverse use of evidence enhances the overall persuasiveness of his writing (makes it the most compelling). To support my claims, I analyze how Appiah's various types of evidence influence reader persuasion, explaining how they appeal to the three persuasive appeals: pathos, logos, and ethos. Additionally, I arrange this evidence effectively, which is essential to #evidencebased writing. The essay begins with an introduction and thesis statement, followed by a logical presentation of evidence that anticipates the audience's need for evidentiary support. I address this using the structure of my body paragraphs; a clear claim, then paraphrased examples from the text, and an analysis of the underlying implications of Appiah's persuasive techniques (what, how, and so what, as discussed in class).[5]

[5] In completing this writing journal assignment, I demonstrated #responsibility by consistently allocating time for each entry, focusing on improving my writing skills. I wrote my reflections after each session, as recommended, to maintain relevance and clarity rather than waiting until the end and risking procrastination. Despite a busy schedule filled with other assignments and courses, I set aside specific time slots in my calendar for journaling and tried my best to adhere to the time intended. I also faced challenges in understanding some prompts, which I addressed by seeking clarification from my professor and consulting friends/peer tutors for guidance on how to approach the #evidencebased HC footnote.

**AI REFLECTION**

I followed the assignment instructions carefully and did not use any AI tools for this task, as requested. My goal was to challenge myself and improve my own writing skills without relying on AI-generated content. However, I did use Grammarly and the built-in spell checker in Google Docs to ensure proper spelling and grammar. These tools helped me catch any basic errors, but all of the ideas and writing are entirely my own.